

# Westpac Card Tracker, 6 May 2026

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Card activity points to stalling growth in discretionary spend



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The **Westpac-DataX Card Tracker Index\*** continues to show a complex mix of factors affecting activity

week to week but with clearer signs of a slowing in discretionary categories starting to emerge. The Index rose 2.1pts over the two weeks to April 25, reversing a similar-sized decline around the start of the month. Some of the variation looks to be due to residual holiday-related softness around Easter.

Quarterly growth momentum remains subdued, holding around a 1% pace as at late April, down a touch on the 1.2% gain in Q1 and materially slower than the 2% average over the previous three quarters. Notably, non-fuel spend is tracking a more subdued 0.5%qtr pace.

Monthly growth continues to track a more volatile path, much of which reflects big swings in fuel prices, spiking in March but with a significant fall in April as the excise tax cut came into effect and a pull-forward in demand subsided. The latest week is tracking a sizeable 1% decline on a monthly basis. Notably, non fuel card activity is also tracking a weak monthly pace, down 0.7%. Some of the latter may be due to the aforementioned residual holiday-related softness.

The category detail provides a somewhat clearer picture that suggests we are seeing an underlying shift in spending momentum. While there is considerable noise coming from both fuel and electricity related activity, discretionary categories, and especially discretionary services, are showing a more pronounced slowdown with data over the last six weeks suggesting this has tipped over into outright contraction.

Six weeks does not quite qualify as a decisive signal for the card data, the 'gold' standard we use being 12 week or quarterly growth rates. The added volatility from holidays and sharp changes in fuel-related activity also means weekly and monthly patterns need to be interpreted carefully. That said, a shift from softening growth to outright contraction in discretionary spend would be consistent with the signs of a deepening 'cost of living' shock to consumers evident in other measures such as consumer sentiment.

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